forthwith. Just because an area is dormant does not mean the problem has gone away. It is dormant because of the intense domination and hold that the unit, any unit, has over the area, which 8 SIKH LI had succeeded in doing. At least for the rest of the field tenure, we would continue to stay there, but I wasn't around to see that either.

I had gone for a spot of leave in April 1999. We were at our house in Vasant Kunj, and some guests had come over for dinner. My friend Arwind Kundalkar, who was the staff officer to the Vice Chief of Army Staff (VCOAS) rang me up. He was a little hesitant on the phone, which was most unlike him. He told me that the result of our promotion board from Lt Col to Col had been declared but that I had not made the cut. I was absolutely shell-shocked and in a daze for the rest of the evening. I had everything going for me, done everything by the book, served all over the country, never refused any job, Staff College, Instructor gradings all around, BM and AQ, two of the most prestigious appointments—what more did the Army want? I would have been placed in 8 SIKH LI to take over in due course, only after an internal screening. Surely there must have been some mistake? I lay awake the whole night. Veena was the only one who understood the entire import of the result. She was a pillar of strength, talking to me gently the whole night, trying to soothe my distressed mind, which was in an absolute jumble of emotions. The next day was no better, my mind kept wandering—what could possibly have happened? Was I really such a *nikamma,* a useless, lazy and incompetent fellow? I tried my best to keep my equanimity, spending as much time as possible with Isha and Amala. They were too young to understand everything but knew that something was amiss.

Gen VP Malik of the SIKH LI was the COAS then. Col Ashok Kapur, who had been my CO, was on his staff

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